

Psalms 18

A Song of Great Deliverance

I will love thee, O Lord, my strength

KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 I will love thee, O LORD, my strength.
- 2 The LORD is my rock, and my fortress, and my deliverer; my God, my strength, in whom I will trust; my buckler, and the horn of my salvation, and my high tower.
- 3 I will call upon the LORD, who is worthy to be praised: so shall I be saved from mine enemies.
- 4 The sorrows of death compassed me, and the floods of ungodly men made me afraid.
- 5 The sorrows of hell compassed me about: the snares of death prevented me.
- 6 In my distress I called upon the LORD, and cried unto my God: he heard my voice out of his temple, and my cry came before him, even into his ears.
- 7 Then the earth shook and trembled; the foundations also of the hills moved and were shaken, because he was wroth.
- 8 There went up a smoke out of his nostrils, and fire out of his mouth devoured: coals were kindled by it.
- 9 He bowed the heavens also, and came down: and darkness was under his feet.
- 10 And he rode upon a cherub, and did fly: yea, he did fly upon the wings of the wind.
- 11 He made darkness his secret place; his pavilion round about him were dark waters and thick clouds of the skies.
- 12 At the brightness that was before him his thick clouds passed, hail stones and coals of fire.
- 13 The LORD also thundered in the heavens, and the Highest gave his voice; hail stones and coals of fire.
- 14 Yea, he sent out his arrows, and scattered them; and he shot out lightnings, and discomfited them.
- 15 Then the channels of waters were seen, and the foundations of the world were discovered at thy rebuke, O LORD, at the blast of the breath of thy nostrils.
- 16 He sent from above, he took me, he drew me out of many waters.
- 17 He delivered me from my strong enemy, and from them which hated me: for they were too strong for me.
- 18 They prevented me in the day of my calamity: but the LORD was my stay.
- 19 He brought me forth also into a large place; he delivered me, because he delighted in me.
- 20 The LORD rewarded me according to my righteousness; according to the cleanness of my hands hath he recompensed me.
- 21 For I have kept the ways of the LORD, and have not wickedly departed from my God.
- 22 For all his judgments were before me, and I did not put away his statutes from me.
- 23 I was also upright before him, and I kept myself from mine iniquity.
- 24 Therefore hath the LORD recompensed me according to my righteousness, according to the cleanness of my hands in his eyesight.
- 25 With the merciful thou wilt shew thyself merciful; with an upright man thou wilt shew thyself upright;
- 26 With the pure thou wilt shew thyself pure; and with the froward thou wilt shew thyself froward.
- 27 For thou wilt save the afflicted people; but wilt bring down high looks.
- 28 For thou wilt light my candle: the LORD my God will enlighten my darkness.
- 29 For by thee I have run through a troop; and by my God have I leaped over a wall.
- 30 As for God, his way is perfect: the word of the LORD is tried: he is a buckler to all those that trust in him.
- 31 For who is God save the LORD? or who is a rock save our God?
- 32 It is God that girdeth me with strength, and maketh my way perfect.
- 33 He maketh my feet like hinds' feet, and setteth me upon my high places.
- 34 He teacheth my hands to war, so that a bow of steel is broken by mine arms.
- 35 Thou hast also given me the shield of thy salvation: and thy right hand hath holden me up, and thy gentleness hath made me great.
- 36 Thou hast enlarged my steps under me, that my feet did not slip.
- 37 I have pursued mine enemies, and overtaken them: neither did I turn again till they were consumed.

- 38 *I have wounded them that they were not able to rise: they are fallen under my feet.*
39 *For thou hast girded me with strength unto the battle: thou hast subdued under me those that rose up against me.*
40 *Thou hast also given me the necks of mine enemies; that I might destroy them that hate me.*
41 *They cried, but there was none to save them: even unto the LORD, but he answered them not.*
42 *Then did I beat them small as the dust before the wind: I did cast them out as the dirt in the streets.*
43 *Thou hast delivered me from the strivings of the people; and thou hast made me the head of the heathen: a people whom I have not known shall serve me.*
44 *As soon as they hear of me, they shall obey me: the strangers shall submit themselves unto me.*
45 *The strangers shall fade away, and be afraid out of their close places.*
46 *The LORD liveth; and blessed be my rock; and let the God of my salvation be exalted.*
47 *It is God that avengeth me, and subdueth the people under me.*
48 *He delivereth me from mine enemies: yea, thou liftest me up above those that rise up against me: thou hast delivered me from the violent man.*
49 *Therefore will I give thanks unto thee, O LORD, among the heathen, and sing praises unto thy name.*
50 *Great deliverance giveth he to his king; and sheweth mercy to his anointed, to David, and to his seed for evermore.*

2 • CONTEXT

Psalms 18 (paralleled in 2 Samuel 22) is David's extended royal thanksgiving after deliverance from Saul and all his enemies, opening with a cascade of names for God as refuge and closing with praise for victories given to the anointed king and his seed forever. Its center features vivid theophany imagery—God's dramatic, earth-shaking descent to rescue—followed by reflection on righteous reward, divine equipping for battle, and international dominion. Henry and the wider tradition read it messianically as well as historically, since ultimate, everlasting mercy to David's "seed" points toward Christ.

3 • VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-3

An opening cascade of praise-names for God—strength, rock, fortress, deliverer, God, strength, buckler, horn of salvation, high tower. David commits to calling upon this Lord who is worthy of praise and who saves him from enemies.

Verse 4-6

The crisis described: sorrows of death compassed him, floods of ungodly men made him afraid, sorrows of hell and snares of death surrounded him. In distress he called upon the Lord and cried to his God, and his voice was heard from God's temple.

Verse 7-15

A dramatic theophany: the earth shakes, mountains move, smoke and fire accompany God's descent, He rides upon a cherub, darkness is His pavilion, hailstones and coals of fire, thunder from heaven, arrows and lightnings scatter the enemy, and the channels of waters are uncovered at His rebuke. This poetic storm-imagery pictures overwhelming, cosmic-scale rescue on David's behalf.

Verse 16-19

The Lord personally draws David out of "many waters," delivering him from a strong enemy and from those who hated him, too strong for him alone. Calamity had come in the day of his weakness, "but the Lord was my stay," bringing him into a large, open place.

Verse 20-24

David reflects on reward according to righteousness and clean hands, having kept the ways of the Lord and not departed wickedly from his God—language of a covenant-keeping king rather than sinless perfection, read in light of God's grace toward him.

Verse 25-29

A meditation on God's character in relation to different kinds of people: merciful with the merciful, upright with the upright, pure with the pure, but showing Himself froward with the froward. God saves the afflicted and brings down the proud; He is David's lamp, lighting his darkness, and He arms him for even seemingly impossible feats—"by my God have I leaped over a wall."

Verse 30-36

Praise for God's perfect way and tried word, His role as a shield for all who trust Him. God equips David physically and militarily—strength, sure feet like a deer's, hands taught for battle, a bow of steel—while His gentleness ("thy gentleness hath made me great") and enlarged path keep David's feet from slipping.

Verse 37-45

Victory imagery intensifies: enemies pursued, overtaken, and consumed; they fall and cannot rise; they cry for help but find none, even to the Lord, because He does not answer them. Foreign peoples and even strangers submit, feigning obedience out of fear once they hear of David’s God-given dominion.

Verse 46-50

Closing doxology: “The Lord liveth... blessed be my rock... the God of my salvation.” God subdues peoples under David, delivers him from violent men, and lifts him above his enemies. The psalm ends by extending this mercy forward: “and sheweth mercy unto his anointed, unto David, and to his seed for evermore”—a promise the New Testament ultimately grounds in Christ.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

God’s deliverance can be as dramatic and total as a cosmic rescue, meeting real weakness with real power, equipping His people for what seemed impossible, and extending His covenant mercy from David to his seed forever in Christ.

Application for life today.

When you recount your own history with God, try David’s pattern: name specific “many waters” He drew you from, not just general gratitude. Ask God for the kind of gentleness-empowered strength described here—not brute self-reliance but a life “made great” by His condescension. And let the final promise of everlasting mercy to David’s seed anchor your hope in Christ, the ultimate Anointed One, whose victory secures yours.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. What “many waters” or “strong enemy” has God drawn you out of in your own story—have you praised Him for it as specifically as David does here?
2. How does verse 35’s claim that God’s “gentleness” made David great challenge assumptions about strength and success?
3. How does this psalm’s trajectory toward mercy for David’s “seed for evermore” point you to Christ, and how does that shape your confidence today?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).